

When he saw her, Polydectes also fell in love with Danaë. He wanted to steal her away from Dictys, but Perseus was a strong young man now, and Polydectes knew he would stand in his way. Polydectes decided to send Perseus on a dangerous mission in the hope that he would not come back. “Perseus, as king of Seriphos, I command you to bring me the head of Medusa,” he ordered.

Medusa had once been a mortal, but Athena had cursed her to become a hideous Gorgon—a monster with hair made of slithering snakes. Anyone who looked into her eyes was instantly turned to stone.

*Perseus would have to use all of his skill and cunning to defeat Medusa.*

First, Perseus traveled to the island where Medusa lived and waited until the dead of night. Then, he carefully walked backward up to her sleeping body, using his polished shield as a mirror so that he didn’t have to look directly at her. Finally, he drew his sword and swung it with all his strength to chop off her head.

Perseus grabbed the severed head, writhing with snakes, and stuffed it into a sack. Even now, he was careful not to look at it, as its power remained.

